



Titian, *The Rape of Europa*, 1559-62 73 x 81 in (185 x 206 cm)

This painting shows Titian moving toward the very loose style of his last paintings, where fluidly modeled forms in opaque colors are overpainted in transparent glazes. The work is alive with movement, with the turbulent figure of Europa echoed in the twisting figures above.

first decade of the sixteenth century, oil paint had become universally established as the prime painting medium in Italy.

It is with later Venetian painters, such as Titian (c.1487/90-1576), and then Tintoretto (1518-94), that we see a freeing up of composition and expression. That these artists were now using oil paint exclusively had much to do with this new freedom of expression, for its flexibility allowed them to take a looser approach, not only in initial stages, but throughout the whole painting process.



Rembrandt van Rijn, *Self-Portrait at the age of 63*, 1669 33 $\frac{3}{4}$ x 27 $\frac{1}{4}$ in (86 x 71 cm)

This painting was made in the last year of Rembrandt's life. The canvas was prepared with a dark brown ground, and the face modeled vigorously using thick Lead White. These impasted brushstrokes give vitality and texture to the face. There is a sense of composure and honesty in this self-portrait, and the sense of gravity is heightened by the flickering shadows that cross his features.



Rachel Ruysch, *Flowers in a Vase*, c.1800 22 $\frac{1}{2}$ x 17 $\frac{1}{2}$ in (57 x 43 cm)

Ruysch was an accomplished and successful still-life painter in 17th-century Holland. She adopted the popular technique of using a red-brown ground as a base, with opaque highlights and transparent darks on top. This ground has the effect of bringing the flowers out of their shadows and into bright focus. Each petal and leaf has been blended with exquisite finesse.

Economical painting

By the seventeenth century, it was common for painters to work in an economical style on a colored surface that provided the mid-tones, while opaque colors were added for lights, and thin transparent darks for shadows. Artists as diverse in style as Caravaggio (1571-1610) and Velázquez (1599-1660) used these dark "grounds" to emphasize any areas of high contrast and create dramatic lighting effects.

Rembrandt (1606-69) often used double grounds on his canvases, with an underlayer of red bole (clay), or red ochre and a layer of gray or brown on top. His images often seem to be sculpted in relief out of the dark ground. Rubens (1577-1640) worked similarly, but often prepared a warm yellow-brown layer that he applied with a bristle brush over a white priming. This underlayer helped him to create images more freely, giving more expression to his painting style.